Moreover, some member states may resist efforts to sideline populists, fearing that the IO might become too independent of or unaccountable to member states. Populists may also hold critical resources, such as unique information (e.g., in the security arena) or substantial funding, that are not easily replaced by other sources. For example, when powerful states like the United States are led by populists, their absence can leave significant gaps in IO operations, funding, information, and moral leadership. Without these contributions, cooperation and momentum may stall.

Sidelining populists also raises normative and legitimacy concerns. Excluding certain states from decision-making processes could reinforce accusations of a "democratic deficit" in global governance (Dahl 1999), wherein IOs are perceived as serving elite interests rather than the broader international community. This perception may alienate not only populist leaders but also their domestic constituencies, fueling further backlash against IOs. Critics might also accuse IOs of overstepping their mandates, acting unilaterally, or wielding disproportionate power. Such perceptions can undermine the trust and credibility necessary for IOs to function effectively, creating long-term challenges even if short-term goals are achieved.

Sidelining can therefore be a valuable tool for IOs, allowing them to navigate the complexities of populist resistance. However, sidelining's success depends on careful calibration. Overuse or misuse can backfire, exacerbating tensions or diminishing an IO's legitimacy.

2.3.3 Appeasing Populists' Constituents

In addition to directly engaging with populist leaders, IOs can take a more indirect approach by appealing to the public—the very constituents populist leaders rely on for their power. By making international cooperation salient and cultivating a favorable image among citizens, IOs can soften public opposition to international cooperation, potentially reducing domestic pressure on populist leaders to resist IO engagement.

IOs have a range of tools to connect with citizens and highlight the tangible benefits they provide. Social media, press releases, and partnerships with local media outlets allow IOs to publicize their contributions, such as development aid, infrastructure development, disaster